The role of digital humanists in university digital transformation: a progress report from Canada

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In the conclusion to his landmark series of articles in the Digital Humanities Quarterly , Patrik Svensson articulated a future for the digital humanities that would see them serve as "a laboratory, innovation agency, portal and collaborative initiator for the humanities, and as a respectful meeting place or trading zone for the humanities, technology and culture, extending across research, education and innovation… [that] could include… other academic disciplines, industry and the art world."[1] For many years, digital humanities scholars have taken on academic leadership roles, applying their knowledge and experience in ways that have improved their universities. Now that "digital transformation" is a preoccupation for higher education institutions, how can digital humanities scholars support their universities so that emerging technologies enable, improve, and add to the individual and collective campus experience, and expand access to university learning?

In fall 2022 Kevin Kee, Dean of the Faculty of Arts at the University of Ottawa, was appointed Senior Advisor to the President, Digital Strategy and Learning Innovation. Kee drew upon his experience as a Canada Research Chair in Digital Humanities to lead a process that reimagined the role of universities in society. His mandate comprised: i. delivering new forms of teaching that would attract the best students; ii. creating opportunities for qualified students who could not move to Ottawa to study with the university at a distance; iii. generating new revenue streams that could be used to enhance the university's research and teaching mission; iv. creating benefits for Canada's capital region, the province and country.

He led a campus-wide consultation, ensuring that the digital strategy gave special attention to: i. belonging (with the university's Vice-Provost, Equity, Diversity and Inclusive Excellence); ii. indigenization and decolonization (with the Office of Indigenous Affairs); iii. internationalization (with the Office of the Vice-President, International and Francophonie); iv. pedagogy and student support (with the Office of the Vice-Provost, Academic Affairs); v. la Francophonie (uOttawa is the world's largest bilingual (English-French) university) (with the Office of the Vice-President, International and Francophonie); vi. lifelong learning (with the Professional Development Institute); vii. emerging technologies (with the Office of the Chief Information Officer).

In addition, he launched a Learning Futures Fund so that professors and staff could develop pilot projects and protypes and create new courses and programs. He created a digital transformation Roadmap to guide academic leaders across the university's ten faculties. Finally, he built financial models and wrote a business case to ensure the financial viability of the university's digital transformation.

This paper is organized in two parts. In part one, the author summarizes the humanistic assumptions that guided his digital transformation planning (such as a commitment to what the Ford Foundation has called "public interest technology"[2] and a culture that promotes what UK Research and Innovation has called "responsible innovation"[3]), and the key elements of his plan for his university's digital transformation. He shows how digital transformation can provide an expanded paradigm that sees universities: i. deliver degree programs and lifelong learning; ii. on the local campus and a global campus; iii. at defined class time during the week and at whatever time best suits a student; iv. to groups of learners and supported by personal artificial intelligence tutors; v. in a lecture hall or laboratory and in digital environments enabled by virtual reality.

In part two, the author provides a progress report on his implementation of the digital strategy in his own Faculty. Faced with both the challenges and opportunities for change on the "front-lines" of the academic mission, he is ensuring that professors, staff and students can implement aspects of the strategy at their own pace. At the same time, he is using his position as an academic leader to enhance and improve the Faculty's structures and systems so that change is possible. The author concludes with several suggestions for how digital humanists, inspired by Svensson's 2012 call to "stimulate visionary and transformative thinking," can support change at their own institutions in a manner that champions the "epistemic traditions" of the humanities. [4]

Notes

1. Patrick Svensson, “Envisioning the Digital Humanties,” *Digital Humanities Quarterly* 6:1 (2012) [accessed December 8, 2024].
2. As the Ford Foundation notes, “technology… holds promise to unlock human potential in ways that seemed impossible mere decades ago. Yet this rapid transformation has far outpaced government services and regulation, legal jurisdiction, public understanding and corporate norms, leaving us all exposed to unchecked harms” https://www.fordfoundation.org/work/challenging-inequality/technology-and-society/public-interest-technology-andits-origins/ [accessed November 29, 2024].
3. See https://www.ukri.org/who-we-are/epsrc/our-policies-and-standards/framework-for-responsible-innovation/ [accessed November 29, 2024].
4. Ibid.

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